ACTIVITY 15

Play a game with a partner.

1 Each of you should choose two characters from different well known TV drama series.

2 Think of three facts about each character and give them one by one to your partner as clues, starting with the most difficult to guess. Award 5 points for guessing with just one clue, 3 for two guesses and 1 for three guesses. (You could make this a whole-class activity with rounds and a final winner.)

Analysing character can revolve around several important areas:

- The character's role in the drama
- Their relationship with other characters
- The ways that the actor brings the character to life:
  - use of voice or accent
  - movement and gesture
  - emotional power to engage with the audience.





14 Characters in soap operas become very familiar to their audiences

KEY TERMS

Central protagonists key characters around whom the text and narrative are centred

Stereotypical grouping people together according to simple shared characteristics, without allowing for any individual uniqueness

The audience can usually spot two main types of characters in a drama – those who are less important and are there for 'padding', and those around whom the main narrative(s) centre. For example, in a medical drama the people who have accidents are only shown for some of one programme, whereas the hospital staff are seen week after week. The less important characters are less developed and often more **stereotypical** than the main characters or **central protagonists** (**14**).

ACTIVITY 16

Watch a clip from any TV drama. Decide which are the less important characters and which are the central protagonists. What information did you use to help you decide?

Setting

The location of a TV drama is important in establishing a sense of a real place where the story can exist. Many regional features may well appear, such as landmarks and the local accent, dress and customs of those who live there.

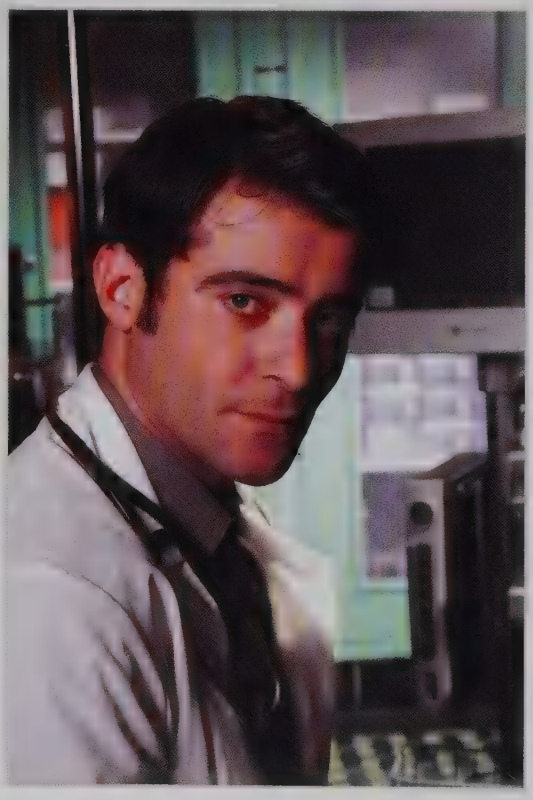
These features are included to encourage as strong a sense of engagement with the world of the drama, the characters and their lives as possible. Audiences continued to remember Dirty Den, for example, long after his exit from Albert Square because he was so perfectly set into the location and community of *EastEnders* – this also explains why his return was so well publicised. Fans of TV drama sometimes write in to their favourite characters, forgetting that they are played by actors and do not really exist.

One of the most important features of most television dramas is that they create believable or realistic worlds that audiences can watch and feel convinced by. The following case study will help you focus on just one sub-genre – the medical drama – in order to see how producers go about creating those real worlds.

Case study – medical drama

Medical drama is one of the most popular sub-genres of drama on television. It has its own set of conventions, all of which are designed to make viewers believe that the world of the programme really exists.

Medical drama developed from soap opera – serialised drama on radio and television paid for by washing powder manufacturers. It became clear that the audience for daytime soap operas – housewives at home during the day – also enjoyed dramas based in hospital wards and in doctors' surgeries. Before long soap operas appeared during peak-time viewing. Early examples included *Doctor Finlay's Casebook* and *Doctor Kildare*, which were extremely popular in the 1960s.



Two of the most popular UK medical dramas of recent years are *Casualty*, which began broadcasting on BBC1 in 1985, and its sister programme *Holby City*, also on BBC1, which began life in 1999. *ER*, on Channel 4, is an American medical drama set in Chicago that also has a large following (see **15**).

15 *ER* is a popular medical drama from the USA

Sometimes the humour is caused by the relationship between the characters – naughty children exasperating fathers or older brothers playing tricks on younger siblings. This comedy arises from the situation people are in, and is therefore called *situation comedy* or *sitcom*.

Humour also reflects people's beliefs and personalities, so they may prefer some programmes to others depending on their own experience.

ACTIVITY 22

Draw a table like the one below. Think of four more examples to add to the list, using your own experience of what you find funny.

Visual comedy	Comedy situations
Dad falls off ladder when son opens upstairs window.	*Naughty son hides school report but 'good' daughter finds it and blackmails him.*

Sitcoms and the family

The sitcom is now a television genre, but it began its life on radio in half-hour shows presenting characters in a common environment such as the workplace or the family home.

Family life has been a subject of sitcom since the early days of television. There have been many types of family represented. In the USA in the 1950s a hit sitcom *I Love Lucy* (**17**) brought to the screens a lovable yet hopeless housewife who was always getting into tricky situations that usually involved misunderstandings with her husband Ricky. The network did something unusual for the times with this live television show – they recorded it. This meant that they could show repeats and attract new audiences as the years went by.



17 Lucy and Ricky from *I Love Lucy*

ACTIVITY 23

1 Read this outline of an original *I Love Lucy* episode. How would Lucy and Ricky look and behave in a new series made for today's audiences? Think about the social changes that have taken place over the past fifty years, especially in the roles of men and women. Suggest ways to bring it up to date and think of comic complications that could happen before all is put right in the end.

Men Are Messy
Tired of cleaning up after Ricky, Lucy divides the apartment into two. He can mess up his half if he wants, but he cannot come into her half.

2 In groups, improvise some of the situations you have thought of. Vote for which you think would work best as an episode of a sitcom.

Although the types of things that go wrong that are the source of humour have not changed over time, other things have. One of the changes in society since the 1950s is that few women now are full-time housewives. Many of the plots of the *I Love Lucy* shows centred on her attempts to gain some independence, suggesting that her husband was very much the boss.

Plots in modern sitcoms still feature the battle of the sexes, but are the women stronger or weaker than the men? Read the article about the British sitcom *My Family* in **18**.



Ben is the harassed centre of the Harper family. His wife Susan is intelligent, sharp, witty and something of a control freak, and their still-loving marriage is a vehicle that may squeak but nonetheless keeps moving along. Ben – though he complains a lot – knows that he has done well in this regard. Susan works as a tour guide, Ben as a dentist, and their home life is complicated by the normal wear and tear of three children. Nick, the eldest, is a lazy, slow-witted incompetent who nonetheless has a certain charm. Janey is a stereotypical teenager, concerned with boys, fashion and looks. Michael is the youngest, a serious, studious boy arguably brighter than his brother and sister. At work, Ben is assisted by his dense hygienist Brigitte (series one) and by son Nick (series two). Janey left to go to university at the start of the third series and returned at Christmas to announce that she was pregnant.

18 *My Family*

TIP

You can find out more about *My Family* by following the links on Heinemann Hotlinks.

KEY TERM

Representation
how the media shape images of people, places and events and present them to the audience

ACTIVITY 24

Discuss these questions with a partner.

1 What do you learn about each family member in the article?
2 Which characters, from their descriptions, do you think have the most power in the Harper household?
3 What kinds of conflicts do you expect between members of the Harper family from what you have learned about their characters?
4 Why do you think sitcom is so often based on family life?

The **representation** of men, women and teenagers in sitcoms is often stereotypical.

- Men are often seen to be weaker than their female counterparts, usually their wives. They may think that they are going to get one over on them, may even look as though they are going to come out on top, but they never win and end up either losing face or losing money.
- The women are often strong characters who keep the whole family on track despite the antics of their hopeless husbands and naughty children.

Do these stereotypes also apply to sitcoms from America? The USA sitcom called *Malcolm in the Middle* also explores what life is like in a family. The narrative style, or the way the story is told, centres on the Malcolm of the title. Read his description of the family as he sees them in **19**.

ACTIVITY 25

1 What similarities are there between the families in *Malcolm in the Middle* and *My Family*?
2 Work together in groups to produce a storyline for Malcolm and his family. Write the first two minutes as a monologue for Malcolm in the style of his journal as below.

My dad's a thinker – none of us knows what about! What my mum says, goes – she's in charge of everything, even the remote control. Francis, my oldest brother, is cool – so he got kicked out. Reese, the next, is dumb, dumb, dumb. And Dewey, the youngest, was only fun until he could talk well enough to tell tales. As for me, Malcolm – well, my skin is clearing up, Reese is in high school so I don't see much of him, and life is getting better – I think!



19 *Malcolm in the Middle*

The strong mother and the exasperated father are represented here in a family situation. The family seem less middle-class than the Harpers, less wealthy and even more dysfunctional, that is, it has difficulty functioning and communicating in emotionally healthy ways.

One of the reasons for the programme's popularity was its ability to present material the audience could identify with. Everyone likes to think their family is perfect, but also knows deep down that it is not, so it is reassuring to see families on television trying to work through problems, as everyone has to do. Could it be that this type of text offers its audience a way of dealing with feelings about their concerns and fears?

Grumpy old men

Another frequent sitcom stereotype is the 'grumpy old man'. Examples from the past include the father in *Steptoe and Son* and Alf Garnett in *Till Death Us Do Part*. More recent texts include *Phoenix Nights*, *Last of the Summer Wine* and US sitcom *Becker*. How many more examples can you think of?

It could be said that in the past comedy was a way for women and children to deal with the authoritarian husband and father figure in many families. The 'grumpy old man' was not only a figure of fun, but often ultimately powerless, as behind his back his seemingly downtrodden wife quietly got her own way. Do modern sitcoms portray this situation in quite the same way? Can you think of any recent sitcoms where the 'grumpy' or 'bossy' role is filled by a woman or a young person? For example, Patty and Selma in *The Simpsons* are both grumpy. What does this say about the changes in family structure?



20 Grumpiest of them all? Victor Meldrew from *One Foot in the Grave*

ACTIVITY 26 EXTENSION

In groups, research the use of the stereotype of the grumpy old man in TV sitcom in the past 30 years. Your research resources could include the Internet, TV listings, books and interviews with older relatives about their favourite grumpy characters. Present your ideas visually and in writing for a wall display.